

said in 1962, "Agriculturists with long experience in Africa know that agriculture can develop only as fast as the farmers can be persuaded to develop it."

This is the place where extension comes in. It is the job of the extension workers to get the facts, already discovered in research, across to the farmer in a usable form. Even more, in developing countries it is the extension worker's job to educate rural people generally so that they can look critically at proposed change and accept or reject it on the basis of sound judgement. "Agricultural extension considered as an educational activity can play a tremendous role in the process of nation building" (Clark 1962).

The Government of Malawi obviously realises the importance of agriculture in the process of nation-building. The importance of extension is also understood as can be seen in the Statement of Development Policies 1971-1980. The emphasis on extension as a means of helping the rural people has been here for quite a while, albeit at times the effort has been misdirected, as during the conservation drive in the late fifties and early sixties. During that drive for better soil conservation, people who did not follow the extension workers' directions were brought to court and fined or imprisoned. The law-enforcement stage of agricultural extension was not, of course, peculiar to Malawi but was a phenomenon of the times, when it was thought that if people did not do what they were told, then they must be coerced.

However, since the election of the Malawi Congress Party to power in 1961 the general approach in extension has become less disciplinary. Since then the idea has been that the agricultural extension staff was to be lenient with the people; rather than forcing them, the extension staff was to educate the people and help them in every way possible. In Malawi today extension is defined as an "informal educational process which aims to teach rural people how to improve the level of living by their own efforts, through making wise use of natural resources at their disposal, in better systems of farming, and homemaking, for the benefit of the individual, the family, the community, and the nation" (Bradfield 1966).

As can be seen from the definition above, agricultural extension in Malawi is basically a rural institution. In fact, the agricultural extension service might better be termed a rural development extension service as it does, in fact do more than just pass on agricultural information. There are other forms of extension in the country, such as community development and health, but of all these agricultural extension is the most widespread and, because of this, has the most obvious visible effect.

Although agricultural extension has, since 1961, been under an independent government and although coercion has ceased, the extension carried out is in the main directive. By this is meant that the rural people are told or advised as to what they should do, without much consultation. In other words, the government and extension workers have decided what is good for the people and have advised them accordingly. This in itself is not necessarily bad, as the ordinary people have so little idea of the needs of the nation that the only way in which to have a rational national approach to rural and agricultural development is by applying a system of direction. The alternative approach of a nondirective system of extension, while very attractive to expatriate staff, is still basically a nonstatist in agriculture in most of Malawi. It is very difficult, after three generations of colonial paternalism superimposed on a technically backward society, to get people to think for themselves and make their own decisions. In fact, it would